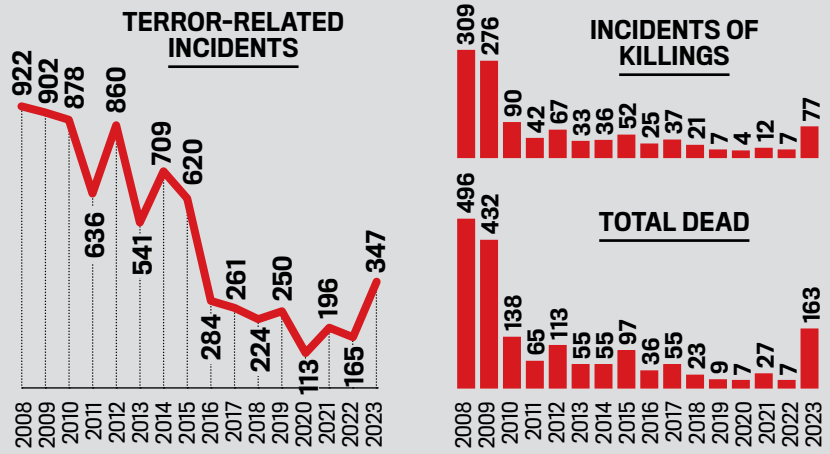
TERROR IS BACK

Terror-related incidents and killings have shot up sharply since last year, though they are nowhere near the alarming levels of the past decade



Source: South Asia Terrorism Portal; *Data till Jan. 25, 2024

(SoO) agreement with Kuki militants, deportation of Myanmarese refugees to Mizoram, implementation of a National Register of Citizens with 1951 as the base year, erecting a fence along the Myanmar border, and removal of Kuki immigrants from the Scheduled Tribe list. Biren Singh, too, signed it later.

However, something more sinister seems to have happened inside the fort, as Congress communication head Jairam Ramesh disclosed—Arambai Tenggol volunteers assaulted Manipur Congress president K. Meghachandra. Other accounts claimed that two other Congress MLAs were manhandled for failing to support the state government in its action against the Kukis.

Arambai Tenggol's growing rise and influence, has been apparent for some time now, especially in the backdrop of the ongoing Meitei-Kuki conflict. But the abject surrender of the state administration, which encouraged the organisation to act with such brazenness, has sent shock waves across the country. That a three-member team of the Union home ministry flew down to Imphal to hold discussions with the group, a day ahead of the Kangla Fort meeting, only added legitimacy to the group. On January 24, when the Arambai Tenggol volunteers headed home, they were cheered by crowds all across Imphal.

What Arambai Tenggol feeds off is the Meitei insecurity over illegal Kuki immigrants from Myanmar and Kuki militant groups, widely perceived by them to be responsible for the ethnic strife that has gripped the state for nine months. Kuki civil society organisations, conversely, allege that Arambai Tenggol, backed and armed by the state government, has been at the forefront of the violence against their community. Both sides, however, have consistently fallen short of substantiating their claims with proof. Arambai Tenggol's growing influence among Meiteis is only rivalled by that of Meira Paibi, the women vigilante group which, in the past, has led drives against drugs, alcoholism and atrocities by the police and armed forces. The armed forces, in fact, allege that Meira Paibis often prevent them from carrying out security operations in the current conflict, and even forced them to release 12 militants once.

MANIPUR FILE

Total dead: 208
(Since May 2023)

Displaced: 50,000

ARMS

Looted: 5,682
Recovered: 1,647

AMMUNITION

Looted: 650,000
Recovered: 23,000

Sensing this consolidation among communities, underground militant groups on both sides are regrouping in Manipur. They had begun losing public support as Manipur limped back to normalcy in recent years. Now, in the name of fighting for their community, they have rearmed themselves, launched attacks on the rival community as well as security forces, even resorting to rampant extortion. Security sources allege that militant groups hiding in the jungles of Myanmar have returned to fight for their community and are training civilians.

The fact that the state administration is functioning in absentia has made the state a fertile ground for breeding militancy. "Who is there to protect civilians?" asks a professor in Manipur University. "The Manipur police is absent in Kuki areas and the central armed forces are ineffective in Meitei areas. So, people are turning to vigilante groups and militia." The proliferation of arms is only compounding the problem. Of the 5,682 arms and nearly 650,000 pieces of ammunition looted by mobs since May, only 1,647 arms and around 23,000 pieces of ammunition had been recovered until January 15. Slowing down the process is the public support for community-based armed groups and the trust deficit in security forces, which is making it difficult to gather human intelligence.

Militant groups are also attacking civilians and security personnel, masquerading as village defence volunteers (VDVs), armed groups of civilians who stood guard at the barracks on village borders during the ethnic clashes. This was evident when rocket-propelled grenades targeted security forces in Moreh in January. On January 19, Manipur's security advisor Kuldiep Singh said that Kuki militants from Myanmar could be involved in attacks on the Manipur Commandos on December 30, when two officers in Moreh were shot dead and over two